

purpose in life, the core of their daily routine; if we're not on this earth to work, what are we here *for*? Finally, many marvelous, intuitive people simply say, "Don't do it. I'm telling you, it just doesn't *feel* right."

Regardless of their reasons for rejecting our idea, we paid careful attention to our friends' advice. My good friend's reaction made me reconsider, for the ten-billionth time, whether I was doing something I would regret. We found helpful pearls of wisdom in even the most irrational outbursts. All of us have to make up our own minds about what we want out of life and whether our jobs are helping us get there. But comments from our friends—all comments—help us think more clearly.

Vicki concluded before I did that retirement made sense for us. But she was careful to let me make up my own mind. Rather than try to influence me, she just smiled and nodded when I told her my thoughts. She was wise enough to make sure I felt it was *my* decision and *my* responsibility.

There's a wonderful end to the story of how family and friends reacted. Once we retired, most were thrilled about the possibilities of our new life. Good friends are like that. They give you honest, straight feedback when you need it. Once you reach a decision, friends care only that the decision makes sense for you. Rather than stick with old opinions, they check to see that you're happy. That you still care about them. That you still want to hear about their promotions and successes on the job. That you don't assume, just because you retired, that it's right for everybody. That you still tell jokes and laugh at life's absurdities. That you still play with their kids. That you still lead active, exciting lives rather than sit around and do drugs. That you observe and learn rather than stare at a TV.

Now, most of our friends wonder why they opposed our retirement in the first place. It was something so right for us, why didn't they see it?